

Readings

Genesis 1:1 - 3:21 - adapted

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. The earth was without form, and void; and darkness covered the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God hovered over the face of the waters. Then God said, "Let there be light"; and there was light. And God saw the light, that it was good; and God divided the light from the darkness. God called the light Day, and the darkness God called Night. So the evening and the morning were the first day.

Then God said,

"Let there be heaven and earth."

"Let there be land and sea."

"Let there be grass and herbs and trees."

"Let there be the sun and moon and stars. Day and night."

"Let there be fish in the water and birds in the air."

"Let there be animals on the land."

"Let us make humankind in our own image."

God created a garden for the man and woman to tend. "Then God blessed them, and God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply; fill the earth and subdue it; have dominion over the fish of the sea, over the birds of the air, and over every living thing that moves on the earth." Then God saw everything that God had made, and indeed it was very good. So the evening and the morning were the sixth day. On the seventh day, God rested.

God gave the humans all of the plants in the garden to eat and commanded them not to eat of the tree of knowledge. The serpent told the woman to eat of the tree of knowledge and she gave the fruit to the man who also ate it. The human's eyes were open. They realized they were naked, sewed fig leaves to cover themselves and hid from God. Because they ate the forbidden fruit, God said to the woman "I will greatly multiply your sorrow and your conception; In

pain you shall bring forth children; Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you."

Then to Adam God said, "Because you have heeded the voice of your wife, and have eaten from the tree of which I commanded you, saying, 'You shall not eat of it': "Cursed is the ground for your sake; In toil you shall eat of it all the days of your life. Both thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you, and you shall eat the herb of the field. In the sweat of your face you shall eat bread till you return to the ground, For out of it you were taken; For dust you are, And to dust you shall return."

Pain is always a sign that we are holding on to something-- usually ourselves.

Pema Chodron

The Problem of Pain

The problem with pain is that we aren't supposed to have it. In Western thought, especially the United States, we don't believe we should have pain. It is all wrong. And we don't know what to do with it when we do have it.

This starts with our origin story. Even if you never bought into it, even if you never believed it, our society's attitudes about the world and our place in it are based on our origin story.

Most of us grew up hearing the first few chapters of the book of Genesis as the story of how God created the world. It's not a scientific treatise. It's actually a poem. The repetition and the cadence are hallmarks of ancient Hebrew poetry. It's also a polemic. At the time it was written, there were dozens of different origin stories, each society claiming that their gods put the universe and the world together. Genesis was the early Hebrews' answer to those other stories; "Here's how we believe it happened."

As beautiful as this poem is, it did set up some unfortunate precedents, such as the superiority of men over women, and the idea that humankind is to dominate the earth. The piece I want to focus on today is the fact that the origin story tells us that when the world was first created and was at its very best, there was no pain. It was paradise.

When sin was introduced, it ruined everything. Because of sin, life became painful. It set up this ideal that life should be easy and carefree. Whatever is hard or hurtful is not how it should really be. And later theology tells us that the ultimate goal is for creation to return to that state of paradise. The lion will lay down with the lamb.

Everything was made perfect. Life wasn't supposed to be hard and we weren't supposed to hurt.

Let that sink in for a minute. Even if you always thought this whole creation myth was rubbish, its implications get into our bones and permeate our society.

Pain tells us that something is wrong, and our origin story suggests that most specifically, we are what is wrong. If we were

better, hadn't messed up, if we had just remained perfect, there wouldn't be pain.

Our immediate response to pain is, "How do we make it stop? How do we make it go away?" In the last few centuries, consumerism has fed off of and exacerbated this problem. "Take this pill. Try this treatment. Read this book, take this class, join this program, follow these six easy steps, ... Purchase our product to get rid of that pesky pain. We'll set you to right."

This whole, largely unconscious and unchallenged belief system sets us up in such a negative way. Distress of any sort is bad, and experiencing it is proof of our imperfection.

But wait! We are Unitarians. We are careful thinkers. We know better than to believe there was ever a time with no distress. And we are Universalists. Our inherited theology is that the Divine is loving and kind and would not subject us to such harsh and reckless experiences. My goodness, we're adults! We know living comes with costs.

Yet, sit with yourself for just a second and dig underneath what we know in our heads. Chances are that like most people, there's a piece of you deep inside that does not believe you should hurt. The fact you are distressed is proof that you and the world are not as it should be. This starting point regarding adversity puts us at a disadvantage.

Compare this with Buddhism. Buddhism states right off the bat "Life is suffering." It doesn't concern itself with how suffering came to be in the world. If a person is shot with an arrow, the Buddhist says "Let's take care of that wound." The focus is on how to deal with the injury. Christian theology first wants to know where that arrow came from. It is not as pragmatic or compassionate as the Buddhist's first response. However, in fairness to the Christian theologians, if there's a high probability that more arrows are going to follow, figuring out where that first one came from is very important information.

In our western world, and especially in the United States, we really don't know what to do with this discomfort. It was not always

this way. Prior to the availability of drugs and treatments that provide pain relief, affliction and angst were just part of life. The foremost concern of people on their deathbeds was what would happen to their immortal soul. In America today, the first fear of dying people is pain.

In my work as a chaplain I've been exposed to many different types of distress - physical, spiritual, social, financial, relational, ecological. It seems there is no end to the ways we can hurt. In my personal life, I've experienced a variety of pains and intensities of discomfort. As a theologian and preacher, I've pondered the existence of suffering and evil for decades. There's a whole lot to say about our experiences of hardship.

This sermon can only skim the surface of this topic. I've decided to do a series of sermons which will allow me to do a deeper dive into different aspects of pain. For today, we'll grapple with the disconcerting fact that we experience these difficulties at all.

In July 2020, the International Association for the Study of Pain updated their definition of pain. It is: "An unpleasant sensory and emotional experience associated with, or resembling that associated with, actual or potential tissue damage." The IASP expanded their definition by adding six key notes: I paraphrase:

1. Pain is always a personal experience and is influenced by biological, psychological, and social factors.
2. Pain is not limited to activity in sensory neurons.
3. People learn about pain through their experiences
4. Believe what a person reports about their own pain.
5. Pain impacts all areas of our lives.
6. There are many ways to recognize pain besides words.

Emotional, Spiritual, and Social Pain have been harder to define. Physical pain is associated with the physical body and the possibility of destruction of physical tissues. Non-physical pains are *"affective experiences that involve more of an abstract and subjective cognitive appraisal that can use symbolic meanings of words, emotions,*

expectations and desires.” - (Understanding emotional pain: A preliminary investigation Ben Weinstein)

The existence of psychological pain is not questioned. It is harder to study, measure, and quantify. Both types of pain show up on brain scans and show up on the same brain circuits. It is interesting to note that the brain processes physical and psychological hurt differently.

Our bodies are not easily divided. Emotional distress impacts the physical body and vice versa. I've always appreciated that old Bible verse, "If one part of the body suffers, every part suffers with it." (1 Corinthians 12:26) If you smash your thumb with a hammer, for a while it seems that everything hurts!

While physical distress is related directly to the physical body, our emotions, spirituality, and relationships are impacted. It's hard to be in a good mood if you have a pounding headache. Chances are you know people who have survived an extended anguish or severe blow and their personalities have gone flat, they've lost trust with the world, or they developed a hair-trigger temper. Sometimes these changes are temporary and the person recovers their former self after the pain has been addressed. Sometimes the changes are permanent.

When the pain is psychological or spiritual, the physical body joins in. Have you ever felt your heart ache, experienced an emotional punch in the gut, or had your feelings hurt? Many physical ailments can be tied to emotional angst. Today trauma specialists stress the need to attend to the somatic experiences of the body for complete healing to occur. Physically, psychologically and spiritually, pain is not easily isolated. We are complex beings.

While all creatures share some experience of pain, there are so many variables. The study of distress is also proving messy. There are many types of pain and they are all highly subjective. Using MRI scans and algorithms, scientists have found that experiences of hurt can be accurately mapped out on the brain's circuitry. Though the same patterns show up in individuals' brains, their reports of

experiences differ significantly. Even the same person going through the same misfortune may feel it uniquely each time.

The neuroscientists have debunked previously held beliefs that certain racial groups do not experience pain in a significant manner. Yet go into the emergency department of almost any hospital and it becomes apparent that people of color still do not receive the same amount of pain medication as white folks.

Additionally, science has now demonstrated that other animals feel distress, both physical and emotional. We are even beginning to understand that plants have a wide range of feelings and different manners of communicating. The study of pain has helped to reunite humanity with the rest of creation on much more equal footing.

Culture, age, gender, time, life experience, and any number of factors influence how we feel pain. Recently I was working with an x-ray technician and asked him about what has surprised him in his field. He told me that it was fascinating to find that generally speaking, older women tended to be the toughest patients. They'd have bones poking out of their skin and suffer the nastiest of breaks, yet they'd just set their face and tell him to do what he needed to do. It embarrassed him that the hardest patients to work with were young men about his age. They were the most vocal and sometimes dramatic about their pain.

Women often complain that the men in their lives turn into big babies when they catch a cold. They whine and snuffle and become demanding about extra comfort and attention. Just a couple weeks ago, I read a study that suggested that men actually do feel colds differently than women. There's a distinct probability that they aren't just being a big wuss!

Some folks have more nerve endings than others. 15% to 20% of humans and mammals fit into a highly sensitive category. This does not mean they are delicate plants or snowflakes. It does mean that they have more feelings and greater intensity in their feelings than most of the population. From an evolutionary standpoint, it

makes good sense. The herd is more likely to survive if there are a few individuals who notice that those rocks are in a different place today than they were yesterday!

Redheads have been found to test differently in pain research studies. The gene that determines hair and skin color is associated with pain reception. People under stress tend to feel pain more acutely. Folks who have experienced pain often are likely to be more tolerant of it. And while different people experience pain differently, individuals also experience pain differently throughout their lives. Pain is so individual and yet so universal.

As complex as hurting is, you'd be surprised how many books, podcasts, websites, and research articles present the three ways to deal with pain.... Or the six steps... or the seven things to try... or the four ways to manage pain.

Most of these various lists begin with just acknowledging that we have a problem. It's surprising how much we want to ignore that fact. From there, it is mostly about attention. There are different ways to attend to our distress, everything from observing it closely to ignoring it altogether.

The meditation master Jon Kabot Zinn, began experimenting with mindfulness as a way to help patients with chronic pain. His Mindfulness Based Stress Reduction program has become the gold standard. There's a certain irony in discovering that an effective way to manage pain is to focus on it intently. Instead of moving away from pain, it is useful to focus on it. The next time you have a headache, before taking aspirin or Tylenol, sit with it for a few minutes. Ask yourself: if this pain had a shape, what would it be? What about its texture? Would it be a certain color? How would it move? Would it have a smell, a sound, or a taste? People often find that even as they are describing their pain in such detail, the details begin to shift.

This separating out of the sensations is called "sensory splitting." It helps people see that what they have been thinking of as a permanent solid block of pain is really many different, constantly

changing sensations. They no longer just lump all negative feelings into the scary all inclusive category of pain.

Stopping and focusing so intently on this distress brings about the realization that we are managing it and it changes moment to moment. There is hope in that constant change.

When people are grieving, I invite them to imagine a picture of their heart. What does it look like, is there a hole in it, is it smashed, is it shredded? Look at it again in a few days or a week. How does it look now? Are there any changes? It's slow, but in time the picture of the grieving heart changes. One day the heart may look not only restored but bigger.

As we think about pain and attention, it's interesting to know that many of the medications that are given to relieve distress do not actually lessen the pain itself. Instead, the patient doesn't mind it so much. Fear and tension associated with the hurt decrease.

There is no one magic way to deal with pain. There are times when healing requires us to explore, express, and honor our pain. Journaling, talking to a therapist, sharing with a chaplain or directed art therapy are useful tools for attending to wounds. Just like when we have a big cut on our skin, it's necessary to go in there and clean it out. It may need to be cleansed, debrated, and bandaged numerous times. If we do nothing except hope that time will heal it, it is likely that the wound will fester and get worse.

Having said this, there are also times when we should leave our pain alone. Healing itself is painful. When the aforementioned cut has a healthy scab, scratching at it will delay the healing, no matter how much it itches. Learning how to sit with your distress, or that of someone else, and do nothing to make it go away, is a learned skill. It's not neglect. It is careful discernment.

One of the most impactful experiences of my life involved just being with my own pain. It was my first experience with a hard grief. While it was an emotional loss, I felt it throughout my body. I

remember being incredulous that a person could hurt so much and still live. It didn't seem possible.

There were good people trying to help me. The more they tried to fix me, the more I was quietly convinced that there was something wrong with me. It was not okay to hurt that badly. I began to work with a spiritual director. One day I sat in her office, telling her about the many woes in my life. She listened non-judgmentally and was quiet for a time. When she spoke, she explained that all of these difficult things in my life were supposed to hurt and I was right on track. She didn't try to fix me. Instead, she blessed my pain.

It became something sacred and right. I was no longer a broken mess. I didn't need to be fixed - but I could use a gentle and sturdy companion as I slowly came back to life.

Sometimes we need to get in there and dig around our distress. Sometimes we need to just be present to it. And sometimes, we need to just ignore it.

This isn't the same as denial. Denial is a legitimate part of the grief process. Instead I'm suggesting that taking a strategic vacation, or intentionally using distraction are legitimate coping mechanisms.

As a chaplain, I might spend a week visiting with a patient and family about a terminal diagnosis. They have been bravely facing it head-on and setting up appropriate plans. Then I would come in one afternoon and hear them talking about the patient's plans to leave the hospital, rent a little two bedroom apartment and get their life back on track. I never challenged those conversations. Those patients were never going to get their lives back. They could, however, take some power back over their lives and create a short break from how hard it had all become.

If a hard situation is honestly acknowledged, if it is looked at truthfully, without minimizing it or catastrophizing the situation, there are many different ways to deal with a difficult reality. No one size fits all.

There is one constant however. We have to acknowledge and accept our trials and tribulations. We can't use distraction or take vacations from it effectively if we haven't admitted the truth of our situation.

This leads us to the spiritual axiom: pain multiplied by resistance equals suffering. Listen to that equation again: pain multiplied by resistance equals suffering.

The word suffering is often a synonym for pain. The suffering that I am speaking about here is very specific. It is a type of hurting that is added unnecessarily on top of the original wound.

When we fight the reality of our affliction, we make it worse. In no way am I saying that we must roll over and let the distress take charge. Instead, I'm referring to acceptance. It is only when we acknowledge the fact of pain in a non-judgemental manner that we can address it wisely. There is a lot of truth in the old saying, "The first step to change is admitting there is a problem."

Acceptance does not mean that we like the situation, that we are resigned to some circumstance, or that we aren't going to try and change our predicament. It means that we acknowledge the existence of our trouble, for now.

Pain is part of the package. No one escapes pain. Suffering, however, is optional.

It's not true that whatever doesn't kill us makes us stronger. It can wear us down, turn us bitter, make us brittle. There are no guarantees that hardship builds character. However, it almost always changes us.

Perhaps you've noticed that there is something solid about people who have been through hard times and who have integrated those experiences into their lives. At some point, these people have met their pain head on and addressed it unambiguously. They have metabolized their trouble. If it has been a powerful hurt, this may have taken years.

To integrate or metabolize carries the ideas of wholeness and access. It's the way that people can take past tragedies and use them in a manner that benefits themselves and others, and not be hurt when going back to that shadowy place. In some ways it is like a physical scar. Once it has mended, a scar rarely hurts, and the skin is usually stronger where the injury has been restored. Wounded Healers do the most good when they no longer have active wounds.

This whole idea of processing one's pain is especially important regarding trauma. People can survive the most horrific events. Traumatic events themselves do not cause post-traumatic stress disorder. When people are given the opportunity and support to process their experience and eventually integrate it, they do not develop PTSD. They may even experience Post Traumatic Growth. People get stuck when they are unable to explore and make meaning of an event. This doesn't mean that we ask every person who has experienced a crisis if they need to talk about it. There are a number of different techniques to process trouble.

It is specifically the metamorphosis and metabolism of pain that can make it transformative. That, however, is a whole other sermon!

There is so much more to say about pain. I have not touched on the relationship of faith and affliction, the purposes and benefits of adversity, specific techniques to address hurt, or the many different types of distress.

For today, my invitation is that you begin to take note of pain, your own and that of other people and creatures. What are your first reactions to it? What are the ways you deal with it and are those methods working? How loud are the internal and external voices that say you shouldn't experience it at all?

Until we meet next, hold in your heart the idea that pain is not inherently evil and that you are not wrong for hurting. Toy with the idea that by honoring your angst, you are right on track.

May your pain rest easily on your shoulders and never become suffering. May you claim what is yours and not allow others to deny it

or add to it. And finally, may you discover ways you can bless your own pain, and that of others.

Amen and Amen

